On 26 June 1975, alleging that the country faced a threat to its unity, Indira declared a state of emergency. The Emergency lasted for twenty-one months, during which time Opposition leaders and activists were jailed, non-Congress state governments dismissed, foreign journalists sent out of the country and the press heavily censored. The Constitution was changed to give Parliament more power and to protect its actions from being challenged in court. Two controversial campaigns, slum demolition in Delhi and a sterilization programme to enforce family planning, were implemented despite widespread resistance. The repressive Emergency was the greatest challenge Indian democracy had ever faced—and it ended only when Indira herself surprisingly called for fresh elections in 1977.



Indira was assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards in October 1984 in retaliation for the violent military action she authorized against Sikh separatists in the Golden Temple in Amritsar earlier that year.

India and Indira

Despite the Emergency, Indira Gandhi was voted back into power in 1980 on a wave of popular support, especially among poorer Indians. Today, she is remembered for her cult of personality and anti-democratic tendencies. However, she continues to command respect for her strong leadership